Please fill out this form, save it to your computer and send it to us with your application. /
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Reference number of the job offer/ Referenznummer der Stellenausschreibung	GIGA-25-09
Surname(s) / Nachname(n)	Gonzalez
Email address / E-Mail-Adresse	gonzalezjj@smu.edu
Given name(s) / Vorname(n)	Javier
Highest qualification (degree, vocational training, etc.) / Höchste Qualifikation (Abschluss, Berufsausbildung o.ä.)	Ph.D. Economics
Current or last position held / Aktuelle bzw. letzte Position	Ph.D. Candidate at Southern Methodist University
Languages / Sprachen	English and Spanish
Available as of / Verfügbar ab	May of 2026

The GIGA promotes equal opportunity and diversity. In order to be able to actively prevent any form of discrimination, we ask for voluntary information on the following points /
Das GIGA fördert Gleichstellung und Diversität. Um jeglicher Form von Diskriminierung aktiv vorbeugen zu können, bitten wir um freiwillige Informationen zu folgenden Punkten.

Gender (female/male/diverse/…) / Geschlecht (weiblich/männlich/divers/…)	male
Nationality / Nationalität	Spanish
Disability / Schwerbehinderung	no

The following information are only mandatory for applications for academic positions. /
Die folgenden Informationen benötigen wir nur für Bewerbungen auf wissenschaftliche Stellen.

Academic title(s) and final grade or GPA / Akademische(r) Titel und Note	BA and MA of Economics
Universities or colleges attended / Besuchte Universität(en) bzw. Hochschule(n)	Southern Methodist University (USA); Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez (Chile)
Main areas of research interest / Wissenschaftliche Schwerpunkte	Applied Economics, Cultural Economics, Political Economy
Title of dissertation (PhD) / Titel der Dissertation	The Cultural Values of Television: Effects of Telenovelas on Behaviors and Attitudes
References from / Referenzen von	Ömer Özak (ozak@mail.smu.edu), Klaus Desmet (klaus.desmet@gmail.com), Wookun Kim (wookunkim@mail.smu.edu)

The collection and processing of your personal application data is exclusively for the purpose of filling vacancies within our institute and will not be passed on to third parties without your prior, expressed consent. / Die Erhebung und Verarbeitung Ihrer persönlichen Bewerbungsdaten erfolgt ausschließlich zweckgebunden für die Besetzung von Stellen innerhalb unseres Instituts und wird nicht ohne Ihre vorherige, ausdrückliche Einwilligung an Dritte weitergegeben.

Deadman College of Humanities and Science
Department of Economics

November 18, 2025

Javier Gonzalez | gonzalezjj@smu.edu
3300 Dyer Street, P.O. Box 0496
Dallas, TX 75275-0496, USA

Dear Hiring Committee:

I am applying for the Postdoctoral Research Fellow position at GIGA. Currently, I am a PhD candidate in Economics at Southern Methodist University, specializing in Applied Microeconomics with an emphasis on Culture, Gender, and Political Economics. I expect to complete my degree by May 2026.

As a Spanish national, my family and I are eager to **return to Europe** so our newborn daughter can grow up immersed in European culture. We are seeking a community with a safe learning environment, a key factor in our decision to **leave the United States**.

My research explores how entertainment media both reflects and shapes economic behavior. I develop novel methods using generative AI to extract cultural values from TV shows and test how these values affect individuals' behaviors and attitudes.

My job market paper "Does Watching Women Work, Work?" provides causal evidence that teenage exposure to telenovelas featuring empowered female characters increases women's subsequent labor force participation. The effects are driven exclusively by portrayals of women in non-traditional careers and narratives that frame empowerment with joy or anger. A second paper shows that telenovelas focused on inequality reduce support for redistribution by downplaying or trivializing issues of economic disparity. My future work will generalize this approach to measure broader cultural values and use AI to analyze diverse media for a comprehensive study of culture.

My research agenda directly aligns with GIGA's commitment to understanding the economic and political underpinnings of inclusive and sustainable development in its key study regions. By employing advanced quantitative methods and AI-driven approaches to analyze cultural influences on economic behavior, I contribute to interdisciplinary and innovative research practices valued by both GIGA and its Economics Department. For example, my job market paper offers insights relevant to policy dialogues around labor and gender equality. Additionally, my experience mentoring a diverse student body reflects my dedication to fostering inclusion and diversity, pivotal to GIGA's institutional values.

Sincerely,
Javier Gonzalez

JAVIER GONZALEZ

Southern Methodist University
Department of Economics
3300 Dyer Street, P.O. Box 0496, Dallas, TX75275, USA
Updated as of 2025-10-15

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jjgecon
click here for lastest version

Education

2021 – **Ph.D in Economics**
Southern Methodist University, USA

2015 – 2020 **B.A. and M.A. in Economics**
Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez, Chile

Research

Research Interests: Cultural Economics, Gender Economics, and Political Economy.

Working Papers

1. **JMP:** "Does Watching Women Work, Work?: The Effect of Mexican Telenovelas on Female Labor Participation"

   Abstract: I study the effect of female empowerment in media on female labor market outcomes using Latin American telenovelas. Using generative AI, I construct a Female Empowerment Index (FEI) for these TV shows from 1960 to 2024. I show that FEI exposure during the impressionable years increases the likelihood of labor force participation among Latin American women. To identify the causal effect of FEI exposure, I implement an instrumental variables strategy using detailed data on television signal coverage in Mexico. The causal estimates confirm the positive effect of FEI exposure, with an effect size comparable to previous studies. Furthermore, FEI changes account for a significant fraction of the aggregate increase in female labor force participation observed over this period. Moreover, both the emotional framing of narratives and the types of jobs depicted play an important role in shaping the effects.

2. "Drama and Redistribution: The Impact of Telenovelas on Preferences for Redistribution in Latin America"

   Abstract: This paper examines how telenovelas depicting inequality affect support for redistribution in Latin America. Using a novel dataset of telenovelas aired from 1960 to 2024 in the region, I employed three Natural Language Processing methods to identify inequality telenovelas. My analysis focuses on instances where a new inequality telenovela is introduced during the LAPOP's fieldwork, ensuring that no other inequality telenovelas are simultaneously airing. Consistently, I observe a 4% reduction in support for redistribution following exposure to such telenovelas. These narratives seem to misrepresent the problems of inequality, portraying fewer issues than are present in reality, making individuals adjust their policy priorities. This study provides evidence of how entertainment media can shape the perceptions of inequality, thereby influencing policy preferences.

Publications

1. "Trade and Ethnolinguistic Differences: A Replication and Extension" joint with Ömer Özak. Economic Inquiry, 2024
2. "Aggregate Costs of a Gender Gap in Access to Business Resources" joint with Francisco Parro. The B.E. Journal of Macroeconomics, 2022

Work in Progress

1. "The Institutional Roots of Culture" joint with Klaus Desmet and Ömer Özak
2. "Telenovelas and Deforestation" joint with Ivan de las Heras and Leonardo Sepulveda
3. "Telenovelas as Cultural Mirrors: Revealing Social Values Through Generative AI"
4. "Multiple Talent Misallocation" joint with Rouzhi Liang

Teaching

Southern Methodist University

Lecturer: Intermediate Microeconomics (evaluation)

Teaching assistant: Macroeconomics (Ph.D.), Quantitative Economics (Ph.D.), Intermediate Macroeconomics, Urban Economics, Applied Econometric Analysis, Strategic Behavior, Financial Economics, and Economic Growth.

Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez (Chile)

Teaching assistant: Macroeconomics II (M.A.), Mathematical Methods for Economists (M.A.), Gender Economics, Game Theory, Econometrics II, Economic Growth, and Macroeconomics

Universidad de los Andes (Chile):

Teaching assistant: Macroeconomics II

Awards, Grants, and Fellowships

2025	Service Melody Rice Memorial Award, Southern Methodist University ($250)
2024	Dedman College Interdisciplinary Institute's Inaugural Graduate Student Summer Research and Writing Fellowship, Southern Methodist University ($3000)
2023 – 2026	Provost's Doctoral Candidacy Fellowship, Southern Methodist University
2021 – 2023	Full Tuition Scholarship and Teaching Assistantship, Southern Methodist University
2021	Poster Award at the 12th Annual Meeting of the Chilean Public Policy Society
2020	Highest GPA of the M.A. cohort, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez
2020	Best Thesis Award at the Annual Meeting of the Chilean Economic Association (SECHI)
2015 – 2020	Academic Excellence Scholarship "Pedro Luis Gonzalez", Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez ($13,000)

Presentations

2025	Southern Economic Association 95th Annual Meeting
	NTxEC, University of Texas at Arlington
	R&I Week Graduate, Southern Methodist University
2024	Southern Economic Association 94th Annual Meeting
2021	12th Annual Meeting of the Chilean Public Policy Society, Poster Session
2020	Chilean Economic Association, Thesis Presentation (Only Speaker)
	Annual Meeting of the Chilean Economic Association (SECHI), Poster Session

Academic Service

2025 –	Peer-to-Peer AI for Research Cohort in Economics, SMU
2025 –	Mentor, ISTC Mentor Matching Engine
2024 – 2025	Tutor, Academic SMU Development of Student-Athletes
2023 – 2025	President, SMU Economics Graduate Club
2022 – 2025	Organizer, SMU Graduate Student Mentorship Program

Affiliations

2022 –	Omicron Delta Epsilon National Honor Society in Economics

Other

Citizenship	Spain, Chile, Guatemala, and Venezuela
Languages	English (fluent) and Spanish (native)
Software Skills	Julia, Python, MATLAB, Stata, Typst and LaTeX
Certificates	NVIDIA: Fundamentals of Deep Learning
	NVIDIA: Fundamentals of Accelerated Data Science
	Constellate: Introduction to Vector Databases and Semantic Searching
	Constellate: Automated Text Classification Using LLMs
	Constellate: Large Language Models and Embeddings for Retrieval Augmented Generation
	Constellate: spaCy in the World of LLMs
	Constellate: Small Language Models

References

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List of Publications

"Trade and Ethnolinguistic Differences: A Replication and Extension" joint with Ömer Özak. Economic Inquiry, 2025.
https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ecin.13269

Abstract: We revisit the role of trade on long-run inter-ethnic linguistic differences. Dickens (2022) hypothesized that neighboring languages are more similar when agriculture provides potential gains from inter-ethnic trade. Since his empirical approach confounds inter- and intra-ethnic trade, we replicate his main analysis using improved measures of potential inter-ethnic gains from trade. Our results confirm the role of trade in inter-ethnic linguistic differences while showing the difficulty of disentangling the role of inter- versus intra-ethnic trade. We also provide an open-source computational framework to replicate both sets of results, which others can use to produce original replicable economic research.

"Aggregate Costs of a Gender Gap in the Access to Business Resources" joint with Francisco Parro. The B.E. Journal of Macroeconomics, 2022.
https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.1515/bejm-2021-0125/html

Abstract: We quantify the aggregate costs of a discriminatory restriction against women in the access to business resources. To do so, we develop a general equilibrium model with an endogenous size distribution of production units, which are run by either female or male entrepreneurs. In this setting, we introduce a distortion that limits the amount of capital that women can use to run their businesses. We calibrate the model to match data from benchmark economies that exhibit relatively egalitarian labor market results between women and men, except in entrepreneurship. Our counterfactual analyses show that a gender-specific capital constraint causes an output loss between 14% and 28% and a fall in aggregate productivity between 12% and 20%. Furthermore, we show that most of the output loss is accounted for by a fall in total factor productivity. Lastly, we show that the aggregate cost of the distortion is mainly triggered by preventing the most skilled women from running bigger businesses, and not the exit of women from entrepreneurship.

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Working Papers

"Does Watching Women Work, Work? The Effect of Television on Female Labor Outcomes"

https://jjgecon.github.io/assets/papers/JMP_Gonzalez_FEI_Telenovelas.pdf

Abstract: I study the effect of female empowerment in media on female labor market outcomes using Latin American telenovelas. Using generative AI, I construct a Female Empowerment Index (FEI) for these TV shows from 1960 to 2024. I show that FEI exposure during the impressionable years increases the likelihood of labor force participation among Latin American women. To identify the causal effect of FEI exposure, I implement an instrumental variables strategy using detailed data on television signal coverage in Mexico. The causal estimates confirm the positive effect of FEI exposure, with an effect size comparable to previous studies. Furthermore, FEI changes account for a significant fraction of the aggregate increase in female labor force participation observed over this period. Moreover, both the emotional framing of narratives and the types of jobs depicted play an important role in shaping the effects.

"Drama and Redistribution: The Impact of Telenovelas on Preferences for Redistribution in Latin America."

Abstract: This paper examines how telenovelas depicting inequality affect support for redistribution in Latin America. Using a novel dataset of telenovelas aired from 1960 to 2024 in the region, I employed three Natural Language Processing methods to identify inequality telenovelas. My analysis focuses on instances where a new inequality telenovela is introduced during the LAPOP's fieldwork, ensuring that no other inequality telenovelas are simultaneously airing. Consistently, I observe a 4% reduction in support for redistribution following exposure to such telenovelas. These narratives seem to misrepresent the problems of inequality, portraying fewer issues than are present in reality, making individuals adjust their policy priorities. This study provides evidence of how entertainment media can shape the perceptions of inequality, thereby influencing policy preferences.

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Research Statement

Entertainment media (e.g., television shows, films, books, and music) are more than entertainment products. As a group, they reflect the cultural norms, identities, and values of the societies that produce them. Yet media can also be a powerful force for change. A single telenovela can drive cultural change by introducing new social issues that challenge the status quo. My research explores this dual role as a cultural mirror that reflects societal values and a driver of social change that shapes economic behavior. My core contribution is the development of novel methods using generative artificial intelligence (AI) to transform unstructured narratives into structured data for rigorous econometric analysis. I apply this framework to Latin American telenovelas, whose deep cultural penetration provides an ideal setting to identify the causal effects of media exposure on real-world economic and social outcomes. Ultimately, this approach offers a new, high-frequency, and scalable methodology for the empirical study of culture and its influence on human behavior.

Job Market Paper In "Does Watching Women Work, Work? The Effect of Television on Female Labor Outcomes," I provide causal evidence that media can be a powerful tool for closing gender gaps. To measure the content of these narratives, I developed a novel Female Empowerment Index (FEI) by applying a generative AI model to the synopses of nearly 2,000 telenovelas. The FEI is based on an augmented Bechdel-Wallace test and includes questions about the employment status of female characters. To overcome endogeneity concerns, I employ an instrumental variable strategy in Mexico that leverages quasi-random variation in television signal loss determined by physical topography. The central finding is that a 10% increase in FEI exposure (20 units) leads to a 4% relative increase in the likelihood of labor market participation (2 percentage points), accounting for a sizable share of female labor force participation growth in Mexico from 2010 to 2020. The effect is driven exclusively by portrayals of women in non-traditional careers and narratives that frame empowerment with positive emotions, demonstrating that how empowerment is portrayed is important.

A second paper, "Drama and Redistribution: The Impact of Telenovelas on Preferences for Redistribution in Latin America," complements this work by showing that telenovelas depicting inequality lead to a counterintuitive decrease in support for redistribution. This study's methodological contribution lies in the comparison of multiple Natural Language Processing (NLP) techniques to identify social class conflict in telenovelas. I compared (i) a dictionary-based approach, (ii) a vector embedding model, and (iii) a zero-shot classification using a generative AI model (ChatGPT). The ChatGPT model outperformed the others in accuracy (74%) and precision (80%). The analysis reveals that exposure to inequality telenovelas reduces support for redistributive policies by 4%. This is because the narratives often

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misrepresent the experiences of marginalized groups, framing them in ways that downplay systemic issues.

My future research will be dedicated to expanding this methodological pipeline. I plan to scale the measurement of cultural values across multiple forms of media worldwide, moving beyond gender and inequality to include other economically relevant values such as community trust, attitudes towards immigration, and environmental protection. Such large-scale data assembly and validation naturally create a collaborative environment. Building on my experience managing research assistants, this work will provide ideal opportunities for undergraduates to gain hands-on experience, serving as human coders to collect data and benchmark AI model performance.

The most innovative step in this research agenda is to move beyond text, leveraging recent breakthroughs in multimodal generative AI to analyze visual and auditory data directly. This expansion will allow the project to include cultural products like movies, books, and music, which transmit essential cultural messages through images and sounds, not just text. Thanks to rapidly advancing AI, state-of-the-art multimodal models such as GPT-4o and Google's Gemini can now process text, images, and audio simultaneously. Applying these tools will enable a far more complete and nuanced extraction of cultural values from these rich media forms.

Lastly, while my research has so far explored the demand side of media, a compelling future direction is the supply side: how producers of these media types decide which narratives to create and disseminate. This new agenda will investigate the extent to which political environments shape media content and whether producers tend to conform to the status quo or push the boundaries of social norms.

My research agenda is driven by a central goal: to show that the narratives in our media have a tangible impact on people's economic lives. Ultimately, this work argues that behavioral change is not only achieved through laws and policies, but also by transforming the very stories we tell ourselves.